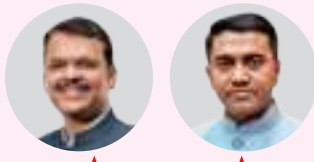
will enshrine that sentiment on the street. In July, MoS home (rural) Pankaj Bhoyar told the legislative council that the bill would be tabled in the winter session. "Already, 10 states in India have an anti-conversion law. We will be the 11th. Our law will be more stringent than those in the other 10 states...," he warned.

Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, who also holds the home portfolio, says the law is meant to prevent conversion through dubious means. "Many such instances have come to light," he says, adding that a committee under the director general of police had been formed to suggest how the law could be fortified. In the Goa assembly, his counterpart Pramod Sawant said he had felt the "need for a law against forcible conversions". Also the home minister, he talks of "several instances (of) targeted" love jihad. For those who came in late, that's a pejorative term suggesting Hindu (or non-Muslim) women are being deliberately entrapped by Muslim men for the purpose of religious conversion in the guise of a relationship or marriage.

Takeaways



- **CMs Fadnavis, Sawant cite need for law to block 'fraudulent' conversions**
- **10 states—including UP, MP, Odisha, Karnataka—have similar laws already**
- **But minorities doubt the governments' intent, claim the law will be misused**

In Goa, despite the BJP's new inroads into the Roman Catholic segment, sections of the Hindu right have used the state's troubled history—the razing of temples and the Inquisition under the Portuguese—to stir up sentiments. What's left unsaid is that, besides the persecution of Hindus, the Inquisition was primarily aimed at neo-Christians, who were suspected of having reverted to their old faith and its practices. And even Christians challenged Portuguese exploitation. Authors Sharmila Pais and Prajal Sakhardande list how Goan priest Matheus de Castro (1594-1678) exposed the racial prejudice of the colonials towards locals, and how the Pinto Revolt (1787), led by local clergymen, sought to overthrow Portuguese rule for similar injustice.

NEEDED OR NOT?

"There are no conversions taking place in Goa. Where's the need to bring in a law?" asks Aleixo Reginaldo Lourenco, independent MLA from Curtorim who supports the Sawant-led state government. "We (the Catholics) are not involved in anything like this. Goa is a peaceful state where people live in harmony." In Maharashtra, Samajwadi Party MLA Rais Shaikh echoes that wariness: "No one supports forceful conversions, but the government's intent is doubtful. Any law will be used to defame communities." Milind Parande of the VHP, on his part, calls for the law to be replicated nationwide, saying: "Hindus don't convert others. The expansionist tendencies of Christianity and Islam put Hindus at a disadvantage."

Past state legislations have laid down procedures for conversion, often mandating an advance declaration to the authorities. In effect, say critics, that has a chilling effect even in genuine cases since law enforcement often ascribes guilt prima facie—while instilling an air of collective fear for the minorities. ■

▶ JAMMU AND KASHMIR

OMAR RAISES THE PITCH ON STATEHOOD

CM Omar Abdullah is forced into hyperactive mode on statehood demand by a spurt of Congress protests

By **Kaleem Geelani**



ANI

RESTLESS Omar Abdullah

NO OTHER STATE OR Union territory would wait so desperately for a Parliament session. But then, no parallel exists for Jammu and Kashmir's misfortune: of being demoted from state to UT, and having to solicit New Delhi's benevolence to have its full statehood being restored.

Nearly ten months into its ascension to 'moth-eaten' power, the Omar Abdullah government seems to have hit the threshold of waiting. A striking image became emblematic of this: the 55-year-old CM scaling the wall of the Martyrs' Graveyard like a young parkour freak, after defying house detention and dodging barriers in Srinagar's downtown on foot to reach the site.

It was the eve of the monsoon session in New Delhi, and he had to